10 QUESTIONS FOR THE BREEDER



Before you say yes to a puppy.

A good breeder loves these questions. A bad one hates them. Print them, take them along, tick as you go.

01 THE PARENTS

- [ ] **1 Can I meet the mom?**
  At the breeder's home, with her puppies. "Not here today" is a red flag.

- [ ] **2 Are both parents health tested?**
  Official X-rays of hips (HD, graded A–E), elbows (ED, 0–3) and shoulders (OCD), graded by the club's specialist, ideally eyes too. Ask to see the papers. Mine: hips A, elbows 0, shoulders clear.

- [ ] **3 Why these two, and how related are they?**
  The inbreeding coefficient (COI) shows it: puppies from half-siblings = 12.5%. At or below the breed average, as low as possible.

- [ ] **4 How long did the grandparents live, and what were they sick with?**
  Some problems, such as epilepsy (often starting at 2–3 years), don't show on any X-ray.

02 THE PUPPY

- [ ] **5 Is the litter registered with the breed club?**
  A pedigree comes from the official studbook (FCI); kennel names can be checked in the FCI directory. In Slovakia, anyone selling puppies must be registered with the regional veterinary office (RVPS).

- [ ] **6 How old will the puppy be when it goes home?**
  My club: at least 7 weeks. Cornell vets: 8–12 weeks. Those weeks with mom and siblings teach bite control and dog manners.

- [ ] **7 What's already done?**
  Microchip entered in the national pet register, first vaccination, at least 2 dewormings. Rabies (from 12 weeks) and boosters come later with your vet.

- [ ] **8 How were the puppies raised?**
  The first 3 months matter most: visitors, noises, car rides, a busy home. Not a back room.

03 AFTER YOU SAY YES

- [ ] **9 Is there a written contract?**
  Price, health, pedigree, and a promise to take the dog back at any age.

- [ ] **10 Can I call you later?**
  Good breeders answer for years.

THE TWIST

A good breeder will question you too: your home, your time, your plans. If nobody asks you anything, that's your answer.

RED FLAGS

- × Puppies always available
- × Many breeds at once
- × Handover at a gas station
- × A deposit before you've visited

TEN QUESTIONS. A FEW AWKWARD MINUTES. TEN YEARS TOGETHER.

Sources: ŠVPS SR (buying a puppy, microchip and registration), Slovak Swiss Mountain Dog club breeding rules, Royal Kennel Club, AKC, FOUR PAWS, Cornell Riney Canine Health Center, AVSAB, WSAVA, FCI, Frontiers in Veterinary Science 2022.

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